

HDcctv

CCTV footage often is blurry and features are not resolved enough for identification. The HDcctv alliance hopes to change that

CCTVs in Kolkata

The City of Kolkata is planning to mount over 100 CCTVs on all busy road intersections

- *Successful CCTV operation is about partnerships. CCTV works best if the monitoring staff are in close two-way communication with those who use the outputs from their systems. Incidents seen on CCTV need to be responded to quickly and appropriately. It's also important for monitoring staff to have real-time access to intelligence networks such as police radio, as well as commercially operated equivalent networks such those within the retail and entertainment industries.*

Big Brother is watching

Has CCTV turned the UK into a surveillance society? Many argue that it has. CCTV is just a tool, like any other, in the law enforcement armoury, so much depends on in whose hands it is used. In recent years there have been a number of high profile incidents that have raised public concerns. In 2005, CCTV control room operators in Merseyside used street CCTV to spy into the home of a female resident and film her preparing to take a bath – they were found guilty of voyeurism and jailed. A test case in the European Court considered the case of a man who was saved from committing suicide by being spotted on CCTV but who later claimed that his Human Rights had been violated when the local CCTV operator released CCTV images – in which he was identifiable – as part of a publicity campaign to demonstrate the value of CCTV. The EU court agreed his Human Rights had been violated. In the UK a number of organisations – including the government's own regulator, the Information Commissioner's Office – have raised concerns about the use of CCTV.

ANPR CAMERAS

Automatic Numberplate Recognition Cameras are special roadside CCTV cameras that capture an image of a vehicle's registration number-plate and then use on-board software to extract the vehicle number as alphanumeric data from the image. Because the cost of this technology has fallen dramatically in the last few years it is now widely deployed for a whole range of applications. Car parks and car rental companies use it for reconciling vehicle inventories; the City of London uses it to detect cars that have failed to pay the daily fee for driving within its limits; petrol stations use it to tackle bilking (the practice of driving off without paying for fuel); and it is the technology at the heart of a new generation of motorway speed cameras that calculate in real-time every vehicle's average speed between two ANPR cameras set a distance apart (forcing motorists to maintain lower average speed over distance, rather than simply slowing down in the vicinity of the camera itself, as with a conventional speed camera).

There is a dynamic between, on the one hand, the police and intelligence services who wish to have as much freedom to surveil whoever they wish and, on the other, civil liberties groups who believe all such intrusions into people's lives should be curtailed. What's the appropriate point between these two extremes that will give the

public the maximum protection for the minimum of privacy intrusion?

Recently the UK Parliament's House of Lords has considered this vexed question, and has made a number of recommendations intended to curtail CCTV's excesses. These recommendations include that CCTV should only be deployed where its use is 'proportional' – where the activity it is to surveil is of sufficient seriousness to justify the intrusion of people's privacy that it will entail; that the use of 'privacy impact assessments' should be considered prior

Since 2005, the police have received central funding to develop a nationwide network of ANPR cameras, positioned at strategic 'pinch points' on the nation's road network, to 'deny criminals the use of the roads'. All of the cameras on this police network feed back to a central police data centre a real-time data stream of every car number-plate passing every camera. This nationwide data can then be searched in real-time for particular vehicles. As with conventional CCTV, the system is only as good as the resources that are available to act on the output it generates. So, for example, seeking data matches against databases held by the Driver & Vehicle Licensing Agency or by insurers to find those driving unlicensed or uninsured vehicles produces such a volume of uninsured or untaxed vehicles that the police simply don't have the resources to stop and detain all the offenders. Notwithstanding, the police ANPR system is proving very effective at quickly finding individual cars, for example, those that have been stolen or used in the carrying out of a crime.



Terrorists on their way



Probable terrorists buying explosive materials

to each new CCTV deployment; and that all CCTV data (including ANPR data) should only be kept for the minimum period defined as necessary within the Operational Requirements. The Home Office and the police have between them produced a National Strategy for CCTV in the UK, which includes the recommendation that, because CCTV necessarily entails privacy intrusion, it should not be everyone who can use it – there should be a licensing/registration/vetting programme for CCTV.

However, regardless of all of this, national surveys of the UK public's attitude to CCTV continue to show acceptance levels for the measure of greater than 80 per cent. 